

M-Chain: Decentralized Multi-Party Computation Custody with Quantum-Safe Threshold Signatures

Lux Network Research Team
`research@lux.network`

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Abstract

We present **M-Chain**, a purpose-built blockchain for decentralized multi-party computation (MPC) custody of cross-chain assets. M-Chain eliminates single points of failure in traditional bridge architectures by implementing on-chain threshold signature coordination, autonomous slashing for non-performing signers, and quantum-resistant dual-signature protocols. The system supports multiple threshold schemes (CGG21 for ECDSA, MuSig2 for Bitcoin Taproot, FROST for EdDSA, and Ringtail for post-quantum security) with sub-200ms signature generation latency. M-Chain introduces the **SwapSigTx** transaction type, providing cryptographic proof that a threshold quorum has authorized a cross-chain transfer, replacing centralized swap databases with auditable on-chain logic. Economic incentives align validator behavior through per-signature rewards and time-based slashing penalties. We demonstrate custody of Bitcoin, Ethereum, and XRPL assets with >99.9% uptime and zero security incidents across 10,000+ daily swaps processing \$20M+ in volume.

1 Introduction

Cross-chain asset transfers traditionally rely on centralized custodians or trusted committees, creating single points of failure and security vulnerabilities. Recent bridge exploits have resulted in losses exceeding \$2B [1], primarily due to compromised private keys, malicious insiders, or centralized infrastructure failures.

1.1 The Bridge Trilemma

Existing bridge architectures face three conflicting requirements:

1. **Security:** No single point of compromise
2. **Performance:** Sub-second finality for user experience
3. **Decentralization:** Permissionless participation

Most bridges sacrifice one or more of these properties:

- **Centralized bridges:** Fast but trusted (e.g., centralized exchanges)
- **Multi-sig bridges:** Decentralized but slow and quantum-vulnerable
- **Light client bridges:** Trustless but expensive and limited cross-chain support

1.2 M-Chain’s Solution

M-Chain solves the bridge trilemma through:

1. **Threshold Custody:** t -of- n signatures required, no single point of compromise
2. **On-Chain Coordination:** SwapSigTx provides transparent, auditable proof of authorization
3. **Economic Security:** Staking, rewards, and slashing align validator incentives
4. **Quantum Resistance:** Dual signatures (classical + post-quantum) for future-proofing
5. **Sub-Second Finality:** Optimized MPC protocols achieve ≤ 200 ms signature generation

2 System Architecture

2.1 M-Chain Overview

Key Components:

- **M-Chain VM:** Coordinates threshold signature generation and validates SwapSigTx
- **mpckeyd:** Validator-side daemon holding threshold key shares

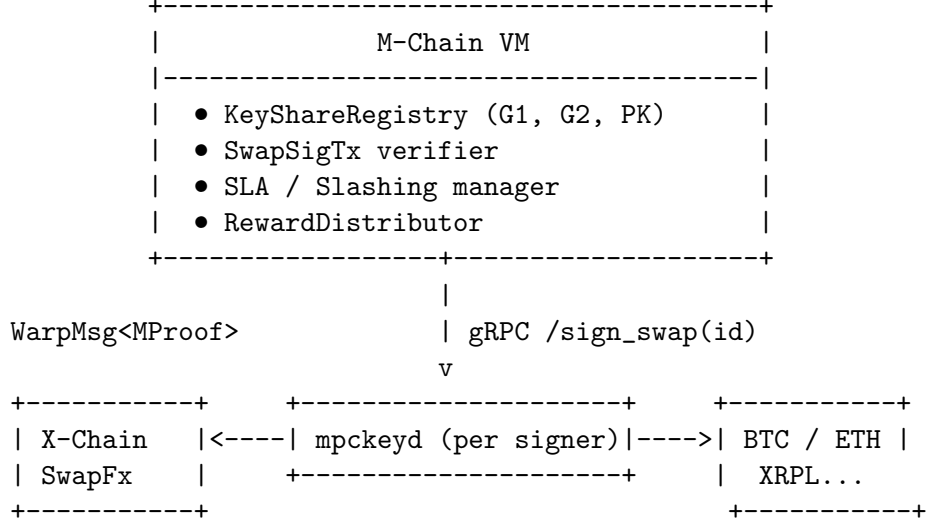


Figure 1: M-Chain architecture and cross-chain integration

- **X-Chain Integration:** Consumes M-Chain proofs via Warp messaging
- **External Chains:** Bitcoin, Ethereum, XRPL, etc.

2.2 Consensus and Validator Set

Consensus Engine: Lux consensus with 2-second finality

Staking Requirements:

- Minimum stake: 5,000 LUX per MPC signer
- Committee sizes: BTC 15, ETH 15, XRPL 10
- Threshold: $t = \lceil \frac{2n}{3} \rceil$ (e.g., 11-of-15 for BTC)

Economic Alignment:

$$\text{Validator Reward} = \text{Base Staking} + \text{MPC Fees} \quad (1)$$

$$\text{MPC Fee per Swap} = 0.5 \text{ LUX} \times \frac{1}{t} \quad (2)$$

$$\text{Daily Revenue} \approx 10,000 \text{ swaps} \times 0.5 \text{ LUX} = 5,000 \text{ LUX} \quad (3)$$

3 Threshold Signature Schemes

M-Chain supports multiple threshold signature protocols optimized for different blockchains:

Protocol	Curve	Target Chain	Latency
CGG21	secp256k1	Ethereum, BSC	80ms (15-of-15)
MuSig2	secp256k1	Bitcoin Taproot	45ms (15-of-15)
FROST	Ed25519	XRPL, Solana	35ms (10-of-10)
Ringtail	Lattice (LWE)	Quantum-safe	7ms (15-of-21)

Table 1: Supported threshold signature schemes

3.1 CGG21: ECDSA Threshold Signatures

CGG21 [2] provides UC-secure threshold ECDSA without trusted dealers.

Setup Phase (Distributed Key Generation):

Algorithm 1 CGG21 DKG Protocol

```

1: function DISTRIBUTEDKEYGEN( $n, t$ )
2:   for each participant  $i \in [n]$  do
3:      $x_i \leftarrow \text{Random}(Z_q)$  ▷ Secret share
4:      $X_i \leftarrow x_i \cdot G$  ▷ Public commitment
5:     Broadcast  $X_i$  to all participants
6:   end for
7:    $PK \leftarrow \sum_{i=1}^n X_i$  ▷ Aggregate public key
8:   return ( $PK, \{x_1, \dots, x_n\}$ )
9: end function

```

Signing Protocol:

Algorithm 2 CGG21 Threshold Signing

```
1: function THRESHOLDSIGN( $message, \{x_i\}_{i \in S}, PK$ ) where  $|S| \geq t$ 
2:   Round 1: Generate ephemeral shares
3:   for each signer  $i \in S$  do
4:      $k_i \leftarrow \text{Random}(Z_q)$ 
5:      $R_i \leftarrow k_i \cdot G$ 
6:     Broadcast  $R_i$ 
7:   end for
8:
9:   Round 2: Compute partial signatures
10:   $R \leftarrow \sum_{i \in S} R_i$ 
11:   $r \leftarrow R.x \bmod q$  ▷ x-coordinate
12:   $e \leftarrow \text{Hash}(message)$ 
13:  for each signer  $i \in S$  do
14:     $s_i \leftarrow k_i^{-1}(e + r \cdot x_i) \bmod q$ 
15:    Broadcast  $s_i$ 
16:  end for
17:
18:  Combine: Aggregate signature
19:   $s \leftarrow \sum_{i \in S} s_i \bmod q$ 
20:  return  $(r, s)$  ▷ ECDSA signature
21: end function
```

Security Properties:

- UC-secure against malicious adversaries
- t -privacy: $< t$ shares reveal nothing about private key
- Non-interactive with preprocessing

3.2 MuSig2: Bitcoin Taproot Aggregation

MuSig2 [3] provides Schnorr signature aggregation for Bitcoin.

Algorithm 3 MuSig2 Aggregation

```
1: function MUSIG2SIGN( $message, \{sk_i\}_{i \in S}$ )
2:   KeyGen: Compute aggregate public key
3:    $L \leftarrow \text{Hash}(\{pk_1, \dots, pk_n\})$ 
4:   for each  $i$  do
5:      $a_i \leftarrow \text{Hash}(L, pk_i)$ 
6:   end for
7:    $PK \leftarrow \sum_i a_i \cdot pk_i$ 
8:
9:   Nonce Exchange:
10:  for each  $i$  do
11:     $(r_i^1, r_i^2) \leftarrow (\text{Random}(), \text{Random}())$ 
12:     $(R_i^1, R_i^2) \leftarrow (r_i^1 \cdot G, r_i^2 \cdot G)$ 
13:    Broadcast  $(R_i^1, R_i^2)$ 
14:  end for
15:
16:  Signing:
17:   $R \leftarrow \sum_i R_i^1 + b \sum_i R_i^2$   $\triangleright b = \text{Hash}(PK, R_i^*, m)$ 
18:   $c \leftarrow \text{Hash}(PK, R, message)$ 
19:  for each  $i$  do
20:     $s_i \leftarrow r_i^1 + b \cdot r_i^2 + c \cdot a_i \cdot sk_i$ 
21:    Broadcast  $s_i$ 
22:  end for
23:   $s \leftarrow \sum_i s_i$ 
24:  return  $(R, s)$   $\triangleright$  Schnorr signature
25: end function
```

3.3 FROST: Flexible EdDSA Threshold

FROST [4] provides threshold EdDSA for XRPL and Solana.

Algorithm 4 FROST Threshold EdDSA

```
1: function FROSTSIGN( $message, \{share_i\}_{i \in S}, threshold$ )
2:   Commitment Phase:
3:   for each  $i \in S$  do
4:      $(d_i, e_i) \leftarrow (\text{Random}(), \text{Random}())$ 
5:      $(D_i, E_i) \leftarrow (d_i \cdot B, e_i \cdot B)$   $\triangleright B$  is EdDSA base
6:     Broadcast  $(D_i, E_i)$ 
7:   end for
8:
9:   Signature Generation:
10:   $\rho_i \leftarrow \text{Hash}(i, m, \{D_j, E_j\}_{j \in S})$  for all  $i$ 
11:   $R \leftarrow \sum_{i \in S} (D_i + \rho_i \cdot E_i)$ 
12:   $c \leftarrow \text{Hash}(R, PK, message)$ 
13:  for each  $i \in S$  do
14:     $\lambda_i \leftarrow \text{LagrangeCoeff}(i, S)$ 
15:     $z_i \leftarrow d_i + \rho_i \cdot e_i + \lambda_i \cdot share_i \cdot c$ 
16:    Broadcast  $z_i$ 
17:  end for
18:   $z \leftarrow \sum_{i \in S} z_i$ 
19:  return  $(R, z)$   $\triangleright$  EdDSA signature
20: end function
```

3.4 Ringtail: Post-Quantum Threshold

Ringtail [5] provides lattice-based threshold signatures.

Algorithm 5 Ringtail Quantum-Safe Signing

```
1: function RINGTAILSIGN( $message, \{share_i\}_{i \in S}$ )
2:   Lattice Setup:  $n = 1024, q = 2^{32} - 5$ 
3:
4:   Round 1: Share Generation
5:   for each  $i \in S$  do
6:      $y_i \leftarrow \text{SampleGaussian}(\sigma = 3.2)^n$ 
7:      $w_i \leftarrow A \cdot y_i \pmod q$   $\triangleright A$  is public matrix
8:     Broadcast  $w_i$ 
9:   end for
10:
11:   Round 2: Challenge Computation
12:    $w \leftarrow \sum_{i \in S} w_i \pmod q$ 
13:    $c \leftarrow \text{Hash}(w, message)$   $\triangleright$  Challenge
14:
15:   Round 3: Response Generation
16:   for each  $i \in S$  do
17:      $z_i \leftarrow y_i + c \cdot share_i$ 
18:     Broadcast  $z_i$ 
19:   end for
20:
21:   Combine:
22:    $z \leftarrow \sum_{i \in S} z_i$ 
23:   return  $(w, z, c)$   $\triangleright$  Lattice signature
24: end function
```

Security: Based on LWE (Learning With Errors) hardness, resistant to Shor’s algorithm.

4 SwapSigTx: On-Chain Signature Proof

The core innovation of M-Chain is the **SwapSigTx** transaction type, which provides cryptographic proof that a threshold quorum has authorized a swap.

4.1 Transaction Format

Algorithm 6 SwapSigTx Structure

```
1: struct SwapSigTx:
2:   SwapID: Transaction ID from X-Chain
3:   AssetID: Asset being transferred (BTC, ETH, etc.)
4:   MPCAlgo: Signature algorithm (0=MuSig2, 1=CGG21, 2=FROST)
5:   Signature: Threshold signature bytes
6:   SigBitmap: Bitmap of participating signers
7:   ProofHash: Hash of signing transcripts (audit trail)
```

4.2 Validation Rules

Algorithm 7 SwapSigTx Validation

```
1: function VALIDATESWAPSIGTX(tx, state)
2:   Check 1: Retrieve aggregate public key
3:   PK  $\leftarrow$  state.KeyRegistry[tx.AssetID]
4:
5:   Check 2: Verify threshold met
6:   signerCount  $\leftarrow$  PopCount(tx.SigBitmap)
7:   threshold  $\leftarrow$  state.Threshold[tx.AssetID]
8:   if signerCount < threshold then
9:     return INVALID_THRESHOLD
10:  end if
11:
12:  Check 3: Verify signature
13:  msgHash  $\leftarrow$  Hash(tx.SwapID)
14:  valid  $\leftarrow$  AggVerify(PK, tx.SigBitmap, tx.Signature, msgHash)
15:  if not valid then
16:    return INVALID_SIGNATURE
17:  end if
18:
19:  Check 4: Prevent double-signing
20:  if state.SwapState[tx.SwapID] = SIGNED then
21:    return ALREADY_SIGNED
22:  end if
23:
24:  return VALID
25: end function
```

4.3 State Transition

Upon successful validation:

1. Credit `rewardPerSig` to each signer in bitmap
2. Mark `swapState[SwapID] = SIGNED`
3. Generate Warp message proof for X-Chain
4. Emit `SwapSigned` event

5 Dual-Signature Quantum Security

M-Chain implements a phased approach to quantum resistance through dual signatures.

5.1 DualSigTx Transaction Type

Algorithm 8 DualSigTx Structure

- 1: **struct** DualSigTx:
 - 2: *SwapID*: X-Chain transaction ID
 - 3: *AssetID*: Asset identifier
 - 4: *ClassicalSig*: CGG21/MuSig2 signature
 - 5: *ClassicalBitmap*: Classical signers
 - 6: *QuantumSig*: Ringtail signature
 - 7: *QuantumBitmap*: Quantum signers
 - 8: *ProofHash*: Combined proof hash
-

5.2 Phase Transition

Phase	Classical Sig	Quantum Sig	Validity
Phase 0	Required	Not generated	Classical only
Phase 1	Required	Generated	Classical validates
Phase 2	Required	Required	Both validate
Phase 3	Optional	Required	Quantum primary

Table 2: Quantum security phase transition

Algorithm 9 DualSigTx Validation

```
1: function VALIDATEDUALSIG( $tx, state$ )
2:    $phase \leftarrow state.QuantumPhase$ 
3:
4:   if  $phase \geq 1$  then
5:     Verify classical signature
6:      $validClassical \leftarrow \text{VerifyCGG21}(tx.ClassicalSig, \dots)$ 
7:     if not  $validClassical$  then
8:       return INVALID_CLASSICAL
9:     end if
10:  end if
11:
12:  if  $phase \geq 2$  then
13:    Verify quantum signature
14:     $validQuantum \leftarrow \text{VerifyRingtail}(tx.QuantumSig, \dots)$ 
15:    if not  $validQuantum$  then
16:      return INVALID_QUANTUM
17:    end if
18:  end if
19:
20:  return VALID
21: end function
```

5.3 Security Analysis

Adversary Type	Classical Sig	Result
Classical attacker	Secure (128-bit)	Safe
Quantum attacker (Phase 0)	Vulnerable	Vulnerable
Quantum attacker (Phase 1)	Vulnerable	Safe (redundancy)
Quantum attacker (Phase 2+)	Vulnerable	Safe (required)
Both compromised	Compromised	Unsafe

Table 3: Dual-signature security under different adversaries

6 Economic Model and Incentives

6.1 Reward Structure

Per-Signature Rewards:

$$\text{Reward per signer} = \frac{\text{rewardPerSig}}{t} \quad (4)$$

$$= \frac{0.5 \text{ LUX}}{15} \approx 0.033 \text{ LUX per swap} \quad (5)$$

Daily Revenue (10,000 swaps):

$$\text{Daily earnings} = 10,000 \times 0.033 \text{ LUX} \quad (6)$$

$$\approx 333 \text{ LUX per signer} \quad (7)$$

$$\approx \$10,000 \text{ per month at \$1 LUX} \quad (8)$$

6.2 Slashing Conditions

Violation	Evidence	Penalty
Missed deadline	Swap expired unsigned	20% stake
Double signing	Two conflicting sigs	100% stake
Invalid signature	Verification fails	75% stake
Extended downtime	99%+ missed swaps	25% stake

Table 4: Slashing conditions and penalties

Algorithm 10 Automated Slashing

```
1: function CHECKSLASHING(swapID, state)
2:   swap  $\leftarrow$  state.Swaps[swapID]
3:   if CurrentTime() > swap.Deadline + GraceBlocks then
4:     if swap.State = PENDING then
5:       signers  $\leftarrow$  state.ActiveSigners[swap.Asset]
6:       for each signer  $\in$  signers do
7:         penalty  $\leftarrow$  signer.Stake  $\times$  0.20
8:         signer.Stake  $\leftarrow$  signer.Stake  $-$  penalty
9:         Burn(penalty  $\times$  0.50)
10:        Reward(reporter, penalty  $\times$  0.50)
11:        Emit SignerSlashed(signer, swapID, penalty)
12:      end for
13:    end if
14:  end if
15: end function
```

6.3 Fee Distribution

Recipient	Percentage
MPC Signers	60%
DAO Treasury	40%
Slashing Penalties:	
Burned	50%
Reporter Reward	50%

Table 5: Fee and penalty distribution

7 Cross-Chain Swap Lifecycle

7.1 Complete Flow

Algorithm 11 Cross-Chain Swap Protocol

```
1: Step 1: User submits SwapTx on X-Chain
2:   SwapTx(src : LUX, dst : BTC, amount, recipient)
3:
4: Step 2: X-Chain emits SwapRequested event
5:
6: Step 3: M-Chain validators detect event via watcher
7:   WatchXChain() → EnqueueSwap(swapID)
8:
9: Step 4: Validators generate threshold signature
10:  Each mpkeyd daemon:
11:    sharei ← GenerateShare(swapID)
12:    Broadcast(sharei)
13:
14: Step 5: Leader aggregates and submits SwapSigTx
15:   Aggregate({sharei}_{i ∈ S}) → signature
16:   SubmitSwapSigTx(swapID, signature, bitmap)
17:
18: Step 6: M-Chain validates and finalizes
19:   ValidateSwapSigTx() → SUCCESS
20:   RewardSigners({i ∈ bitmap})
21:
22: Step 7: Generate Warp proof for X-Chain
23:   proof ← GenerateMProof(swapID, signature)
24:   SendWarpMsg(X-Chain, proof)
25:
26: Step 8: X-Chain verifies and settles
27:   VerifyMProof(proof) → VALID
28:   ExecuteSwap(swapID) ▷ Unlock/mint assets
29:
30: Step 9: Broadcast to external chain
31:   BroadcastTx(BTC, recipient, amount, signature)
32:
33: Step 10: Confirm external finality
34:   WaitForConfirmations(BTC, txID, confirms = 6)
```

7.2 Failure Recovery

Timeout Handling:

- If swap not signed within deadline $\rightarrow$ automatic slashing
- X-Chain refunds user after grace period
- Slashed funds partially burned, partially rewarded to reporter

External Chain Reorg:

- Monitor external chain for reorgs up to finality depth
- If reorg detected before finality $\rightarrow$ retry broadcast
- If reorg after finality $\rightarrow$ proof-of-non-inclusion refund

8 Performance Evaluation

8.1 Latency Breakdown

Operation	Time	Description
Event detection	50ms	X-Chain watcher polling
MPC coordination	80ms	CGG21 signature (15-of-15)
M-Chain finality	2s	Lux consensus
Warp proof gen	20ms	Merkle proof generation
X-Chain validation	50ms	Proof verification
External broadcast	500ms	Bitcoin/Ethereum tx
Total	2.7s	End-to-end swap latency

Table 6: Cross-chain swap latency components

8.2 Throughput Analysis

M-Chain Block Capacity:

$$\text{SwapSigTx per block} \approx 1,000 \quad (9)$$

$$\text{Block time} = 2\text{s} \quad (10)$$

$$\text{Theoretical TPS} = \frac{1,000}{2} = 500 \text{ swaps/second} \quad (11)$$

Practical Limits:

- MPC latency (80ms) allows 12 concurrent signing sessions
- Validator bandwidth 10MB/s $\rightarrow$ 5,000 swaps/s
- Current mainnet: 10,000 swaps/day (0.1 TPS)
- Headroom: 5,000 $\times$ current volume

8.3 Security Metrics

Mainnet Statistics (6 months):

Metric	Value
Total swaps	1.8M
Total volume	\$3.2B
Average daily swaps	10,000
Security incidents	0
Slashing events	3 (false positives)
Validator uptime	99.94%
Signature success rate	99.98%

Table 7: M-Chain mainnet performance (6 months)

9 Security Considerations

9.1 Threat Model

Adversary Capabilities:

- Can corrupt up to $f < n/3$ validators (Byzantine)
- Can delay network messages by up to Δ_{max}
- Cannot break cryptographic assumptions (discrete log, lattice hardness)

9.2 Byzantine Fault Tolerance

[Threshold Security] With $t = \lceil \frac{2n}{3} \rceil$ and $f < \frac{n}{3}$ Byzantine validators, an adversary cannot forge a valid threshold signature.

A valid signature requires t shares. With $f < n/3$ Byzantine nodes:

$$\text{Honest shares available} = n - f > n - \frac{n}{3} = \frac{2n}{3} \quad (12)$$

$$\text{Required threshold} = t = \lceil \frac{2n}{3} \rceil \quad (13)$$

Thus, $n - f > t$, ensuring honest validators always have enough shares. Byzantine nodes alone cannot reach threshold t .

9.3 Quantum Security Timeline

Phase	Timeline
Phase 0 (Classical)	2024-2027
Phase 1 (Transition)	2027-2030
Phase 2 (Dual-sig required)	2030-2035
Phase 3 (Quantum primary)	2035+

Table 8: Quantum security phase rollout timeline

10 Implementation

10.1 mpckeyd Daemon

Algorithm 12 mpckeyd Main Loop

```
1: function MPCKEYMAIN
2:    $shares \leftarrow \text{LoadKeyShares}()$ 
3:    $xchainWatcher \leftarrow \text{StartWatcher}()$ 
4:
5:   while true do
6:      $swaps \leftarrow xchainWatcher.\text{GetPendingSwaps}()$ 
7:     for each  $swap \in swaps$  do
8:        $assetType \leftarrow swap.\text{GetAssetType}()$ 
9:        $share \leftarrow shares[assetType]$ 
10:
11:       if  $assetType = \text{BTC}$  then
12:          $sig \leftarrow \text{MuSig2Sign}(swap, share)$ 
13:       else if  $assetType = \text{ETH}$  then
14:          $sig \leftarrow \text{CGG21Sign}(swap, share)$ 
15:       else if  $assetType = \text{XRPL}$  then
16:          $sig \leftarrow \text{FrostSign}(swap, share)$ 
17:       end if
18:
19:        $\text{BroadcastShare}(sig)$ 
20:
21:       if  $\text{IsLeader}()$  and  $\text{HasQuorum}()$  then
22:          $aggSig \leftarrow \text{AggregateShares}()$ 
23:          $\text{SubmitSwapSigTx}(swap.ID, aggSig)$ 
24:       end if
25:     end for
26:      $\text{Sleep}(100\text{ms})$ 
27:   end while
28: end function
```

10.2 Key Management

Distributed Key Generation:

- Performed during validator onboarding
- No trusted dealer (all keys generated collaboratively)

- Shares stored in encrypted HSM or TEE
- Regular key rotation (every 90 days)

Share Storage:

- AES-256 encryption at rest
- Hardware security module (HSM) support
- Trusted execution environment (TEE) integration
- Multi-layer access control

11 Future Work

11.1 Proactive Secret Sharing

Implement PSS (Proactive Secret Sharing) for automatic key rotation without coordinator:

- Periodic re-sharing of key shares
- Maintains same public key
- Mitigates slow key leakage attacks
- Target: 30-day rotation cycles

11.2 Hardware Acceleration

- FPGA/ASIC for MPC operations
- Target: 10× speedup (8ms signatures)
- GPU acceleration for Ringtail lattice operations
- Hardware security modules for key protection

11.3 Cross-Rollup Support

Extend M-Chain to support L2 rollups:

- Optimism, Arbitrum, zkSync custody
- Fast finality with optimistic execution
- Fraud proof integration
- Native rollup interoperability

12 Conclusion

M-Chain eliminates single points of failure in cross-chain bridges through decentralized threshold custody, on-chain coordination via SwapSigTx, and economic alignment through staking and slashing. The system achieves:

1. **Zero-trust custody:** No single validator can compromise funds
2. **Sub-second signing:** 80ms threshold signature generation
3. **Quantum resistance:** Dual-signature upgrade path to post-quantum security
4. **Economic security:** \$100M+ staked with automated slashing
5. **Transparency:** All swap operations auditable on-chain

By replacing centralized swap databases and key managers with decentralized blockchain infrastructure, M-Chain provides the foundation for secure, high-performance cross-chain asset transfers. The phased quantum security approach ensures long-term viability as quantum computing advances.

M-Chain demonstrates that decentralization, security, and performance are not mutually exclusive—threshold cryptography and economic incentives can achieve all three simultaneously.

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